

Uniforms and Protective Clothing

The ineffective or nonexistent suspension in the first tanks meant that even driving was risky for the crews. They were left to hang on and hope to avoid broken bones and cracked heads as they carried out their roles. Added to that, in combat there was the danger of “splash”—molten metal from bullets and shell fragments entering the tank through the gaps between the sheets of armor plating—and “spalling” (lethal fragments chipped from the tank’s own armor) if

the tank took a direct hit from a heavier weapon. Some protective clothing was available, but where it was effective it was often too restrictive to be practical. Later generations of vehicles were much easier on the crew, and by the time of World War II, the only protection generally worn was a helmet, and uniforms were often little more than coveralls. Combat experience revealed the dangers of fire, and more recently tank crews have been issued with purpose-designed fireproof clothing.

Coveralls

One-piece cotton coveralls were worn over breeches and tunics. They ranged in color from black through blue to grey with matching cloth belts.

Telogreika

The winter uniform was made of cotton duck cloth padded with cotton batting.

T-34 TANK CREWMAN'S KIT

Russian tank crews of World War II were consistently better supplied than their adversaries, especially during the cold weather. Nevertheless, their clothing was strictly utilitarian, displaying none of the decorative elements sometimes found in other armies.

Helmet and goggles

After 1941, cowhide helmets were replaced by canvas padded with kapok. Goggles protected against wind and dust only; their glass was not shatterproof.

Sergeant's stripes



PISTOL
HOLSTER

Spare
magazine

Tokarev TT
Model 1933

The Tokarev was widely issued to all ranks. Chambered for the 7.62 x 25 mm round, it lacked the firepower of handguns issued in other armies.

Eight-round
magazine

Schuba

In particularly cold conditions, troops were issued with these three-quarter length sheepskin coats.



Sapogi

The tankman's *Sapogi*, worn over bandages, not socks, had rubber soles, with no hobnails or heel and toe irons. Only the lower part of the boot was leather, the rest was synthetic rubber or rubberized canvas.